

AL JAZEERA MEDIA INSTITUTE · PROFESSIONAL TRAINING

Build Your Project

DAY 2 TAKEAWAYS — Film Festival Submission: from idea to rough cut

Inside this guide: the ideation toolkit (no AI required) · the script-doctor prompt pack · the shotlist template · production discipline rules · rough-cut method · the festival submission checklist.

Trainer **Abdullah Abudiak**

Founder & CEO, The Agency — Dubai

Instagram @a.abudiak · [linkedin.com/in/abdullahabudiak](https://www.linkedin.com/in/abdullahabudiak)

1 · Build the Idea — Without AI

The strongest thing in your film is the one thing no model can supply: a reason to care. Do this part on paper.

The logline formula

One sentence, four slots

When [CHARACTER] faces [PROBLEM], they must [ACTION] — or [STAKES].

Test it: read your logline to another group. If they can't repeat it back accurately, it isn't a logline yet — it's a vibe.

Three tests every idea must pass

- **The 90-second test** — Can the whole arc — setup, turn, resolution — happen in 60–90 seconds? If it needs more, you have a feature pitch, not a workshop film. Cut to one moment of change.
- **The feeling test** — Name the single emotion the last frame should leave behind. One word. Every shot you generate tomorrow either serves that word or gets cut.
- **The generatable test** — Be honest about what AI video does well in 2026: atmosphere, motion, faces, places — and what it struggles with: complex hand interactions, long dialogue scenes, precise choreography. Design toward strengths.

The three-beat spine

- **Beat 1 — Setup (0–20s)** — Establish who and where, and plant the question. The first shot is a promise to the audience.
- **Beat 2 — Turn (20–60s)** — Something changes, complicates, or reveals. This is the reason the film exists.
- **Beat 3 — Resolution (60–90s)** — Pay off the question. Endings are remembered — spend a disproportionate amount of your thinking here.

Team roles for the day: director (owns the vision), producer (owns the shotlist and the clock), editor (owns the cut). Everyone prompts; one person decides.

2 · The Script-Doctor Prompt Pack

Paste your logline and beats into Gemini, Claude or ChatGPT, then run these. AI proposes — the team disposes.

The attack pass

Here is our logline and three beats: [PASTE]. Attack it like a harsh festival juror: what is cliched, what is confusing, what is emotionally flat? Be specific and brutal. Do not rewrite it — only critique.

The options pass

Give me 5 alternative endings for this story, each in one sentence, each landing a different emotion. Rank them by originality and tell me which one a festival audience would remember a week later — and why.

The clarity pass

A viewer sees this film cold, with no context. Beat by beat, what will they NOT understand? Where do we rely on information that is only in our heads?

The compression pass

Rewrite this voice-over so it is half the length and twice as concrete. Replace every abstract word with an image you can see. Keep the meaning, kill the filler.

The title pass

Give me 10 titles for this film: 3 literal, 3 poetic, 3 provocative, 1 single word. For each, one line on the expectation it sets.

The shotlist draft

Turn these three beats into a numbered shotlist of 12–15 shots for a 75-second film. For each shot: description, shot type (wide/medium/CU/insert), duration in seconds, and the audio that plays over it. Front-load visual variety.

How to use the answers

- **Vote, don't drift** — Every AI suggestion gets a 30-second team vote: adopt, adapt, or reject. No silent merging of ideas — that's how films lose their voice.
- **Keep your darling** — If the model attacks the part your team loves most, defend it consciously. Knowing why you keep something is as valuable as knowing what to cut.

3 • The Shotlist: Your Production Contract

If it's not on the list, it doesn't get generated. Copy this table — one row per shot, 12–18 rows for a 60–90 second film.

#	Shot description	Type	Dur.	Generation method	Audio plan
01	Establishing: city skyline at dawn, haze breaking	Wide	5s	T2V — Veo 3.1	Ambience, score in
02	Hero close-up, looks toward the light	CU	4s	Keyframe (NB Pro) → I2V Runway	VO line 1
03	Hands open the old letter on the desk	Insert	3s	Keyframe → I2V	SFX paper, room tone
04	Hero walks into the crowd, away from camera	Tracking	6s	I2V + character Reference	VO line 2
...					

How to break down your story

- **Beats → shots** — Each of your three beats becomes 4–6 shots. Open every beat on a new visual idea — new location, new framing, or new subject.
- **Vary the grammar** — Alternate wide / medium / close. Two same-size shots back-to-back read as a mistake; three read as a style. Choose deliberately.
- **Mark the hard three** — Flag your three riskiest shots (complex motion, character interaction, specific action). Generate those FIRST — if one proves impossible, redesign while there's still time.
- **Plan audio per shot** — The audio column is not optional. A shotlist with empty audio cells produces a silent rough cut and a panicked final hour.
- **Duration honesty** — Sum the duration column. If it exceeds 90 seconds on paper, it will exceed 120 in the edit. Cut on the page, where cutting is free.

4 • Production Day Discipline

Your Runway account is your camera department and credits are your film stock. Teams that finish share these habits.

Before the first video generation

- **Build the consistency kit** — Generate your character, location and key prop as still reference images first. Lock them as Gen-4 References / Veo ingredients. Every shot draws from the same kit — this is what makes 15 clips feel like one film.
- **Write all prompts before generating any** — Draft the full prompt for every shot in a shared doc using the six-part formula. Reviewing 15 prompts takes 10 minutes; regenerating 15 bad shots takes your whole afternoon.

During generation

- **Two-take rule** — Maximum two takes per shot on the first pass. Finish the whole film, then spend remaining credits re-rolling only the weakest shots. An incomplete masterpiece loses to a complete film — in this festival and every other.
- **Turbo for tests, 4.5 for finals** — Iterate on Gen-4 Turbo, lock the prompt, then run the final on Gen-4.5. Same prompt, better engine, half the waste.
- **Save every seed and prompt** — Log the seed + prompt of every accepted take next to its row in the shotlist. Tomorrow's fixes depend on being able to reproduce today's wins.
- **Name files like an editor** — GroupA_Shot03_Take2.mp4 — group, shot number, take. Your rough cut speed tonight is decided by your file names this afternoon.

Division of labour while rendering

- **Nobody watches progress bars** — While shots render: one person preps the next prompts, one records/generates VO and pulls SFX, one builds the edit timeline with placeholder slates. Render time is production time.
- **Poster frame en route** — Generate your festival poster still in Nano Banana during a render gap — don't leave it for tomorrow's deadline hour.

5 • The Rough Cut Method

Tonight's goal is a complete, watchable assembly — not a finished film. Structure first, polish tomorrow.

- **1 • Assemble blind** — Lay every shot on the timeline in shotlist order without judging. You cannot evaluate a film that doesn't exist end-to-end.
- **2 • Audio bed before trimming** — Drop in VO, music and key SFX at rough levels. Audio changes the perceived pace of every cut — trimming before sound means trimming twice.
- **3 • Cut for rhythm** — Trim the first and last beat of every shot; generated clips almost always breathe too long at both ends. If a shot doesn't earn its seconds, it goes.
- **4 • Kill transitions** — Hard cuts only in the rough. Dissolves and effects hide structural problems you need to see tonight.
- **5 • The cold watch** — Play the full cut once, no pausing, as a team. Each person writes down ONE confusion and ONE drag point. That list is tomorrow morning's entire agenda.

Festival submission checklist — due Day 3, before lunch

■	Final film	60–90 seconds, with sound, exported (1080p minimum)
■	Title + logline	Final — this text becomes your film's web page on the festival portal
■	Poster frame	One still image (Nano Banana render or frame grab)
■	Credits	Team members and roles
■	AI toolchain	Tools used per stage (image / video / audio)
■	AI disclosure	One line stating what was AI-generated

Tomorrow the submission happens through the festival portal: your title, logline, poster and credits are turned automatically into your film's own web page. Structured input → instant publishing — the same automation logic you'll reuse in your newsroom.

6 • One-Page Cheat Sheet

The whole day on one page.

DO	DON'T
Lock the idea on paper before opening any AI tool	Let the model pitch the idea — you'll get the average of the internet
Write every prompt before generating anything	Prompt-improvise shot by shot until credits run out
Build the consistency kit (character, location, prop) first	Generate shots with a different-looking hero in each one
Two takes max, finish the film, then re-roll the weakest	Perfect shot 1 while shots 2–15 don't exist
Rough-mix audio before trimming the cut	Leave sound for 'the end' — there is no end, there's a deadline

Day 2 vocabulary

Logline — The film in one sentence: character + problem + action + stakes.

Beat — A unit of story change; this film has three.

Shotlist — The numbered production contract — one row per shot.

Consistency kit — Reference images of character, location and prop reused across all shots.

Coverage — Having enough shot variety to cut the scene more than one way.

Assembly / rough cut — All shots in order with rough audio — complete, not polished.

Picture lock — The moment you stop changing the cut (tomorrow, not tonight).

Stay in touch

Tag your behind-the-scenes: [@a.abudiak](#) on Instagram · LinkedIn: [linkedin.com/in/abdullahabudiak](https://www.linkedin.com/in/abdullahabudiak).

Tomorrow — Day 3: final cut, portal submission, screening and awards. Bring your rough cut and your fix list.